

FX Insight

China - CNY appreciation delayed, not derailed

The pause in CNY appreciation should not be mistaken for a turning point. While official resistance is likely to limit the pace of gains, ongoing exporter USD conversions should continue to provide support. We maintain our constructive CNY view and remain long CNHINR.

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CNY appreciation has stalled for now. There was some excitement when USDCNY broke below 6.80 in early May, followed by further fanfare when the daily fixing was set below this level on 10 July—the strongest CNY fixing against the USD since February 2023. However, the break below 6.80 did not mark the start of another sharp leg of CNY appreciation; instead, it has been followed by a period of consolidation.

We believe the medium-term outlook for the CNY has not changed materially and continue to expect gradual appreciation against the USD following this near-term pause. We maintain our forecast for USDCNY at 6.65 by end-2026, modestly stronger than forwards, although this implies a slower pace of appreciation than seen in recent months. Our rationale is as follows:

1) The PBoC continues to lean against the pace of appreciation. While the gap between the official USDCNY fixing and market-implied fixing has narrowed in recent weeks, the fixing has consistently been fixed consistently weaker than market expectations over the past several

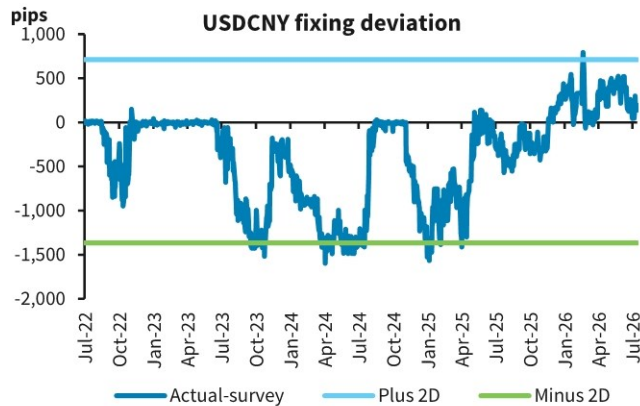
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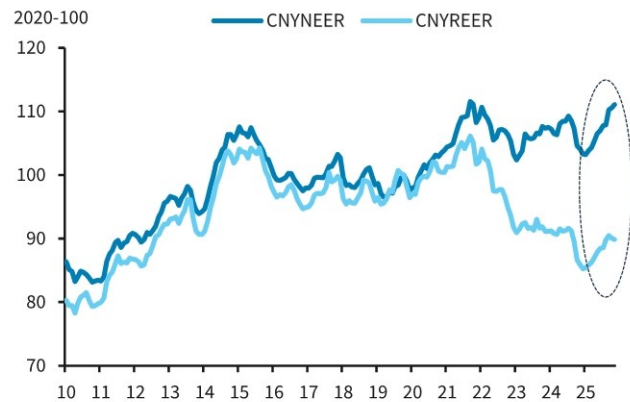
months (Figure 1). This suggests that policymakers remain uncomfortable with a more rapid pace of CNY appreciation, even if they are broadly tolerant of its direction. We see little reason for the PBoC to materially alter this stance in the near term.

FIGURE 1. CNY has been fixed consistently weaker than the market over recent months



Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. CFETS CNY has appreciated over recent months



Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

2) The CNY's relative strength is becoming a consideration. The CFETS CNY trade-weighted index is now close to its highest level since August 2022. While this has not yet become a major concern given the continued resilience of China's exports, the margin for further appreciation may be narrowing. With domestic demand having softened further, policymakers can't afford to lose export competitiveness. Moreover, the CNY's real effective exchange rate (REER) has also moved higher in recent months, albeit from previously depressed levels, reinforcing the case for a more measured pace of appreciation.

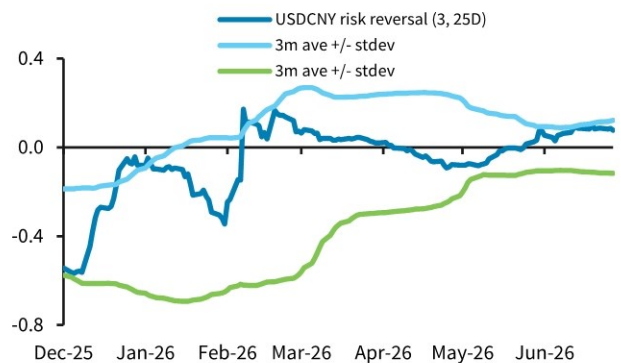
3) Exporter USD conversion flows are likely to remain supportive, but less so than before.

Although China's trade surplus remains substantial, we expect exporter USD conversions to moderate in the months ahead. Such conversions have already slowed from earlier peaks but remain elevated by historical standards, suggesting that upward pressure on the CNY should persist, albeit at a reduced pace. We do not anticipate a significant slowdown in exports in the near term. However, a firmer USD environment could encourage exporters to retain a larger share of their foreign currency receipts rather than immediately converting them into CNY (Figure 3).

4) Onshore CNY sentiment has become less constructive. Sentiment indicators have turned less supportive of further CNY gains. Given the dominant role of financial institutions in onshore FX trading, changes in market pricing can provide a useful gauge of domestic sentiment. In particular, 3-month 25-delta risk reversals have become less CNY-bullish compared with earlier this year (Figure 4). While positioning remains far from outright bearish, the shift suggests that expectations for rapid CNY appreciation have moderated, reducing a potentially important source of momentum for the currency.

FIGURE 3. China exporter USD conversions could reduce amidst USD strength

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 4. Risk reversal skews have become less bullish as onshore CNY sentiment softens

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Stay long CNHINR. Given our expectation for only gradual CNY appreciation against the USD—even against the backdrop of a large trade and current account surplus—we continue to favour relative-value opportunities and maintain our [long CNHINR recommendation](#). While we believe it would take a significant shift in fundamentals for the CNY to reverse course from current levels, we are mindful that a broad-based USD recovery could lead to a sharper slowdown in exporter USD conversions and temper the pace of appreciation.

China has also introduced measures to limit capital outflows, which should help contain downside pressure on the CNY. Importantly, these measures suggest that, despite recent currency strength, policymakers remain reluctant to see a renewed depreciation cycle in the currency.

1) Authorities have tightened oversight of outbound investment channels. Since late May, regulators have stepped up scrutiny of cross-border stock trading and other offshore investment channels, consistent with an effort to retain capital domestically and support local financial markets¹. This follows the expansion of outbound investment regulations to explicitly cover individual investors for the first time, broadening the authorities' ability to monitor and manage capital outflows².

2) New outbound investment regulations increase official control over overseas flows.

Effective 1 July 2026, the revised Outbound Investment Regulations establish a more comprehensive approval and review framework for overseas investments, with greater emphasis on national security considerations and enhanced oversight from the NDRC, MOFCOM and SAFE. The new framework gives policymakers greater discretion to slow, delay or reject large outbound transactions should they judge them to pose risks to capital flow stability or the balance of payments.

Taken together, these measures reinforce our view that policymakers are seeking to moderate the pace of CNY appreciation rather than engineer a weaker currency. While official resistance and slower exporter conversions argue for a more gradual appreciation path, ongoing external

¹ Beijing Curbs Outflows Despite Yuan's Strength: China Today - Bloomberg, 8 June 2026

² China Expands Outbound Investment Rules to Cover Individuals (1) - Bloomberg, 3 June 2026

surpluses and tighter management of capital outflows should continue to provide underlying support for the CNY.

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